> messenger of any suspicious developments. Our subjects must not create major clashes between two nations because of minor incidents.[9]

But, as was the case with Mongolia's declaration of independence, Tibet's was also ignored by outside powers. Britain and other countries continued to recognize Chinese suzerainty over Tibet as well as Mongolia. But suzerainty does not amount to sovereignty. Originally a term used to define to the relationship between the Ottoman Empire and its surrounding areas, it simply means that a certain area recognizes the overlordship of a suzerain to whom it is supposed to be paying tribute. But, in reality, it often refrains from doing so. It means, in effect, internal autonomy with the suzerain power in charge of little more than foreign relations and, perhaps, defence. In the context of the chaos that reigned in China in the 1910s, it was a formal designation with no meaning. Both Mongolia and Tibet were if not de jure, at least de facto, independent nations.

In order to regulate the status of Tibet and to define its borders, British India's foreign office on 23 May 1913 sent an invitation to the Chinese government to a joint conference where representatives from the Tibetan government would also participate. The three parties eventually met at Shimla (then Simla), the summer capital of India in the foothills of the Himalayas, on 13 October 1913.

British India's chief negotiator, Henry McMahon, a Shimla-born colonial official, also served as the chairman of the conference. He was assisted by Archibald Rose, a former consul to China, and Charles Bell, the then British Political Representative to Sikkim on issues concerning Tibet. On the British side was also a remarkable man whose full name was Sonam Wangdel Laden La, or Laden La for short. He was an ethnic Bhutia from Sikkim and among the many languages he spoke were Tibetan and English. Laden La had accompanied Francis Younghusband during his military expedition to Lhasa in 1903–4, and was now a high-ranking police officer with security-related duties. Laden La had just returned from a trip to Britain when he was sent to Shimla to act as an interpreter for the Tibetan delegation during the final days of the conference. He arrived on 21 June 1914 and stayed until 21 July.[10]

Tibet sent Prime Minister Lama Lönchen Shatra to represent the Dalai Lama. The chief Tibetan negotiator was assisted by a delegation consisting of Trimon Norbu Wangyal and Khenchung Tenpa Dhargyal, two other